

CDD:

Game Title: IDENTITÄT

Genre: Coming of age psychology / Narrative Adventure

Platform: PC/Console

Target Audience: Ages 12+, players who feel 'lost' or 'stuck' in their lives and want a new start/players who want to know how to forge their identities and move past a specific event in their lives

Document Version: v1.0

Author: Ihita Pillutla

Date: 04/04/2026

1. High Concept Overview

“**IDENTITÄT**” is a narrative-driven psychological coming-of-age game set in early 2000s Freiburg, Germany. The player begins their first day of high school, only to experience a sudden identity-shattering incident that leaves them injured and unable to clearly remember what happened. As the game progresses, the player must reconstruct their identity through choices, interactions, and exploration. Rather than assigning a fixed personality, the game allows players to *become* someone through their decisions.

The game blends:

- Narrative exploration
- Choice-driven identity building
- Psychological memory reconstruction

The core idea is: ‘You don’t discover who you are, you create it instead’

2. Game Pillars / Design Goals

- Identity as a System: The player's personality is shaped through gameplay choices, not presets
- Choice = Self-Definition: Every dialogue and action contributes to who the player becomes
- Psychological Storytelling: Memory is fragmented, symbolic, and slowly reconstructed
- Safe Exploration of Heavy Themes: Sensitive topics (kidnap, assault) are implied and handled with care instead of explicit scenes
- Grounded Realism + Inner Distortion: Real-world school life contrasts with unstable internal perception

3. Target Audience

- Players who enjoy narrative-heavy games
- Fans of psychological and coming-of-age stories
- Players interested in self-reflection and choice-based gameplay
- Ages 12+

This game appeals to players who prefer emotional engagement over fast-paced action, similar to narrative indie experiences, players who feel 'lost' or 'stuck' in their lives and want a new start/players who want to know how to forge their identities and move past a specific event in their lives

4. Genre + Platform

- Genre: Psychological Narrative / Adventure
- Platform: PC (keyboard/mouse), optional controller support
- Session Length: 1-2 hours per playthrough
- Replay Value: High (multiple identity outcomes)

5. Core Gameplay Loop

- Wake up → explore school environment
- Interact with classmates and teachers
- Make dialogue and behavioral choices
- Build personality traits (identity system)
- Unlock memory fragments
- Reflect consequences through world reactions
- Progress toward different identity outcomes

6. Mechanics Overview

Identity System (Core Mechanic):

Instead of stats, the player develops traits through actions:

- Confidence ↔ Hesitation
- Trust ↔ Suspicion
- Kindness ↔ Defensiveness

NPCs react dynamically based on these traits.

Dialogue System:

- Branching conversations
- No “right” answers
- Choices influence identity and relationships

Memory Fragment System:

- Triggered by locations, people, or emotions
- Presented as:
 1. Distorted visuals
 2. Symbolic environments
 3. Partial recollections
- Gradually reveals the “identity break” event

Exploration System:

- School (classrooms, hallways, infirmary)
- Nearby streets and safe zones
- Interactive objects that reveal personality traits

Relationship System:

- Classmates and teachers respond based on player behavior
- One key classmate acts as a grounding presence
- Trust levels affect dialogue and story direction

7. Theme, Setting + Aesthetics

Setting

- Freiburg, Germany
- Early 2000s (2001-2003)
- High school environment

Visual Style

- 2D or 2.5D narrative style
- Soft, muted colors for reality
- Warped/distorted visuals for memory sequences

Audio Design

1. Normal State:

- Ambient school sounds
- Soft early-2000s style background music

2. Memory/Distortion State:

- Echoing voices
- Muffled audio
- Subtle unsettling tones

8. Progression + Replayability

Multiple identity outcomes based on player choices:

- Resilient Identity (growth and strength)
- Withdrawn Identity (avoidance and isolation)
- Defensive Identity (guarded and distrustful)
- Balanced Identity (self-aware and stable)

Replayability comes from:

- Different dialogue choices
- Different personality paths
- Alternate memory interpretations

9. Emotional/Player Experience Goals

Players should feel:

- Curious about themselves
- Emotionally engaged with choices
- Responsible for their identity
- Tension when recalling fragmented memories
- Satisfaction in shaping their own personality

The game aims to create self-reflection, not just entertainment.

10. Competitive Analysis

Unlike traditional narrative games:

- No fixed protagonist personality
- Identity is player-built, not pre-written

Unlike simulation games:

- Focus is psychological, not mechanical

The game stands out through its **identity-as-gameplay system**, similar to how other indie narrative games innovate within their genres

11. Scope + Feasibility

Estimated Development Time: 4-6 months

Team Size: 3-5 people

Required Roles:

- 1 Game Designer
- 1 Narrative Designer
- 1 Programmer
- 1 Artist (2D/UI)
- 1 Sound Designer (optional - can find free sounds on pixabay)

Scope Control:

- Limited map (school + small area)
- Dialogue-driven gameplay
- Reusable environments

Overall Complexity: Medium (feasible for student project)

12. Future Expansion

- Additional story arcs
- Expanded character backstories
- More identity traits and outcomes
- Mobile adaptation
- Voice acting for key scenes

13. Monetization

Chosen Monetization Model: Premium

The game will follow a Premium monetization model, meaning players pay once to purchase the full game and receive the complete experience without additional required purchases.

Why this model fits this game: The Premium model is the most suitable choice for “IDENTITÄT” because the game is heavily focused on:

- Narrative depth
- Emotional immersion
- Player-driven identity building

Unlike live-service or casual games, IDENTITÄT is designed as a **complete, self-contained experience**, similar to other narrative indie games

1. Protects Immersion

This game relies on emotional storytelling and psychological engagement.

- Interruptions like ads or purchase prompts would **break immersion**
- Players need uninterrupted focus to connect with the story
- Premium ensures a **continuous, distraction-free experience**

2. Supports Identity-Based Gameplay

Since the core mechanic is **building identity through choices**:

- Locking choices behind payments would feel unfair
- Pay-to-unlock personality paths would damage the concept

Premium keeps all choices **equal and meaningful**

3. Matches the Game's Tone

IDENTITÄT is:

- Reflective
- Personal
- Slow-paced

Aggressive monetization (timers, energy systems, etc.) would:

- Ruin the emotional tone
- Turn a meaningful experience into a transactional exp

4. Fits Indie Narrative Design

The game has:

- A defined story
- A clear beginning and ending
- High replayability through choices

This structure works best as a **complete product**, not an ongoing monetized system

How the Game Avoids Unethical Monetization

1. No Pay-to-Progress

- Players will NOT pay to unlock:
 1. Story content
 2. Identity paths
 3. Dialogue options

2. No Manipulative Systems

The game will NOT include:

1. Energy bars
2. Waiting timers
3. Daily login pressure
4. Fake urgency tactics

So, players can play at their own pace without any sort of pressure

3. No Gambling Mechanics

- No loot boxes
- No random paid rewards
- No hidden probabilities

4. Respect for Player Time

- The game is designed for meaningful sessions (1–2 hours)
- No forced grinding or repetitive loops

5. Optional Future Content (Ethical DLC)

If additional content is added later:

- It will be clearly priced expansions
- No hidden costs
- No required purchases to enjoy the base game

14. ADDITIONAL ELEMENTS

MAIN ELEMENT:

The primary thematic focus of **IDENTITÄT** is: '**WHO**'

The entire game is built around the idea that identity is not fixed, but shaped through:

- Choices
- Experiences
- Reactions to difficult situations

The supporting elements are:

- **WHERE:** Freiburg, Germany (grounds the story in realism)
- **WHY:** uncovering the cause of memory loss (drives narrative motivation)

HOW THE GAME GOES WITH THE THEME:

The theme of "**Who am I?**" is directly translated into gameplay:

The player **inputs their name**, but nothing else is predefined. Personality is formed through:

- Dialogue choices
- Actions
- Emotional responses

The memory loss event removes any fixed identity, forcing the player to: actively build themselves instead of discovering a preset character

The game reinforces the theme by:

- reflecting player choices through NPC reactions
- changing how the world responds based on identity traits
- gradually revealing past events that challenge the player's perception of self

ALTERNATE STRATEGIES (thinking process + how i came up with the game):

During the brainstorming phase, multiple approaches were considered:

Option 1: Mystery/Crime Game:

- Focus on solving the kidnapping as the main mechanic
- Rejected because:
 - too plot-focused
 - did not strongly connect to the “who” theme

Option 2: Horror Survival Game

- Focus on escaping danger and threats
- Rejected because:
 - relied on fear rather than identity
 - reduced emotional depth

Final Direction: Identity-Based Narrative

- Focus shifted to:
 1. Self-discovery
 2. Psychological growth
 3. Player-driven personality

This approach was chosen because:

- it directly answers the theme “Who”
- it creates a unique mechanic (identity as gameplay)
- it allows emotional and meaningful player engagement

WHY IS THE GAME FUN

Player Freedom

- No fixed personality

- Players can experiment with different behaviors
- Each playthrough feels unique

Meaningful Choices

- Every decision affects:
 1. Relationships
 2. Identity
 3. Story direction

So, players feel that their actions matter

Mystery & Discovery

- Players uncover:
 1. what happened
 2. who they are
 3. how others see them

So that the curiosity keeps players engaged

Replayability

- Multiple identity outcomes
- Different dialogue paths
- Alternate emotional experiences

Emotional Engagement

- Players connect to:
 1. Characters
 2. Personal growth
 3. Self-reflection

The game is fun not just mechanically but emotionally as well

HOW + WHY ARE WE PUNISHING THE PLAYER

So, instead of traditional punishment (like losing health or restarting levels), IDENTITÄT uses narrative consequences.

How the Game Punishes

- NPCs react negatively to certain behaviors
- Relationships can weaken or break
- Dialogue options may close off
- The player may develop:
 1. Distrustful
 2. Isolated
 3. Defensive identity paths

Why This Punishment is Used

The purpose is NOT to frustrate the player, but to:

- reflect real-life consequences of behavior
- reinforce the theme of identity
- encourage thoughtful decision-making

Design Philosophy

Here: "Punishment" = Reflection

So instead of:

- "You failed the game"

The game says:

- "This is who your choices made you become."

For Example

- If a player consistently avoids others:
 1. they become more isolated
 2. fewer support systems appear in the story
- If a player is overly trusting:
 1. they may face emotional consequences (like someone betraying them, etc)

Why I Think This Works

- Makes choices feel real
- Encourages replayability
- Strengthens emotional impact